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Travel Radio Australia and we're here in Khan at the fabulous Mappik show which is all about entertainment facilities for people, for tourists, for theme parks, all that sort of thing and I have Eric Nearguard with me. He's the Chief Executive Officer of THG Creative from Pasadena, California. Eric, welcome to the program.

Well, thank you for having me, it's a pleasure to be here. Your company THG Creative actually creates some of the best theme park rides, all sorts of experiences for all over the world, internationally you were telling me, as well as the United States. Tell us a bit about the company itself.

So we're a design and production company that specializes in making iconic attractions, theme park rides, museum exhibits, cultural centers, observation decks. We take it from the very beginning, the blue sky, what's the big idea, take it all the way through the design process and then we can turnkey that for our clients and ultimately open it up for the visitors to experience. And what we like to do is we really like to focus in on what is the story, what is the thing that makes this special, that creates something that resonates with people, that can create a memory, that they can walk away with and then of course want to come back to and enjoy that.

And regardless of what type of field it goes into. Telling me that you've just done an attraction for Knott's Berry Farm in Southern California and I grew up around that area, went to school at Westminster High actually, so just down the road. These sort of iconic theme parks, not just in America but around the world.

Tell us about the latest thing you've put into there. So we did some work with Knott's Berry Farm, it was the Fiesta Village and it was the refresh. It hadn't been touched in quite a long time and what it did is it celebrated the Hispanic cultural connections and the many different types in Knott's Berry Farm in Southern California and it really brought about a lot of life to that particular area.

It opened it up, brought a lot of color. We created these alabrihas which are kind of a folk art characters that are really colorful and then put it those throughout the land. Basically revitalized that whole section.

We did that a couple years ago, it was a very big hit for them and now the land looks great. And what's your background Eric? How did you get into all of this fantastic fantasy world? I have been in the sort of location-based entertainment for about 30 years. I started in 1996 as a show set designer on the amazing Adventures of Spider-Man attraction at Universal's Islands of Adventure.

From there I did work with Sony Development in Tokyo and Berlin. I've worked on attractions I mean for the last 30 years and I started my own company Theme Space doing work with Universal and Paramount as a freelancer and then eventually that grew and grew and about six

years ago merged with the head of a group and now we are THG creative and we have two offices one in Orlando and one in Pasadena and we do work internationally and it's been a an incredible ride I would say. Literally.

And tell us about some of the international places you're into and some of the attractions that you've created there. Oh sure. So we did a really interesting project for the Galaxy Group in Macau and it's the Crystal Pavilion.

It has something like 380,000 custom crystals that are individually programmed in this three story pavilion. It's a whole light show. There's moving chandeliers that come down and the roof flips over and there's fountains underneath and it's all basically to tell the stories of whatever is happening in the festivals of the season to draw people into the casino and they literally have buses that come and drop people off just so they can watch the show.

So that was something we actually built and delivered right in the middle of COVID which I would have to say is you wouldn't want to do that again but it turned out to be lovely and quite beautiful. I actually worked with the USA Pavilion in Yosu, Korea back in 2012. That was all about oceans and we worked with Philippe Cousteau.

The whole theme was based around the oceans and the waters and life. That was a thrilling fun thing to do. We've done a lot of work in the Middle East, a lot of concept development, things I can't quite talk about because they're still under NDAs.

That's one of the biggest challenges. Some of our greatest work, we don't really get to talk too much about it until years and years later. So by right now there's a lot of wonderful projects that I'd love to tell your audience about but I can't.

That's okay and tell us some of your standout rides that you've created that are your absolute favorite, your babies that I would say. So we recently opened up the top of the rock observation deck at the Rockefeller Center and in that it tells the story of the building of Rockefeller Center during the Great Depression and what it took to to do that. It also expands on everything that you can do while you're there but one of the key spots is there's this historic photo of the builders on the beam eating lunch.

It's lunch on top of skyscraper. Everyone knows that but no one knew that that was actually for Rockefeller Center and so we ended up creating a beam experience on the top of the observation deck where it'll take you up, rotate you around, you're sitting on the beam, you get a look at Central Park and you get your photograph taken with it in the background and it connects you back to that experience of that moment of just and it's actually in the same spot where those workers were and it's a great example of how you can take a story and make it an experience and connect people back to it. Now there's also the skylift that's also on the roof and it takes you up 30 feet in the air and does a 360 view of New York City and then it's the best view and frankly

right there in Midtown and you get to see everything and those are two great rides you know attractions that you can do.

We recently opened up so if you're in New York I would definitely go and see that so that was a fun one. The other one's a high roller in Las Vegas so that's the big observation wheel. At the time it was built it was the largest observation wheel in the world now it's number two behind Dubai but it will take you on a 30-minute rounder circle and if you get in one of the cabs it's a happy hour and so you can have as many drinks as you want in that amount of time it's a lot of fun but it's very elegant very beautiful it sits above the skyline as which is really noisy and you know I mean it's Vegas it's kind of an elegant feature across the whole city so that's another one of our attractions that we've done that's quite fun and then you know we do a lot of work for some of the studios but again I can't talk about those.

Sure the movie business is a very very closely connected to guys like yourself so they come to you and they say look we're making a film can you help us with these special effects you must be doing a few of those. For actual films what we typically do is we will create media for our attractions we will work with different media providers for when they come in and say alright this is if the ride vehicle will be here they will see this for so long in that media X Y & Z happens and then we'll usually connect that to something that happens in the ride like it's okay if the vehicle is going to pitch left then and the fire effect goes off to the right and times with the sequence of what's happening in the particular ride then that's usually what we're doing trying to pull that whole story together and how that how that all functions. And of course with the emergence of artificial intelligence it's really a big game-changer isn't it for these sort of things and I suppose you must be working with that very closely too.

Artificial intelligence is well it's fascinating how it's getting woven into our industry hasn't quite landed yet it's it's something that I would say everyone is investigating as to where it can be best utilized and we're not. We have clients that will say please we don't want you to use it at all even though they're using it and we have others that are like please use it you know and what we found at least where we're at right now is that it can be very helpful to speed up or amplify because when you need to be very particular about something I need it to be exactly this way it doesn't really dial in that well. Big moves I'm trying to figure out the mood or the idea or express an idea quickly to get approval but as far as like no what is it what is it going to be and what is the final product yeah we're not finding that it really goes to that level and then from that perspective it's it's good for initial ideation that's that's how that's what we find it to be good for.

A fascinating area is the holographic field and I know that a lot of people are you can already see it there's there's the ABBA shows and all these and Elvis shows it's getting really advanced now isn't it. Visual effects are visual illusions you know have a long long history going all the way back to Pepper's ghost effects which have been used a great effect in many attractions and museums now what you're seeing is basically that same kind of base illusion but now amped up with higher resolution and like so the the ABBA Voyage show is a great example of how to utilize 3d effects

in an LED screen but where they really are successful is that they they take that idea and they they go beyond the stage and they go into the virtual space as well simultaneously so they're telling the audience all of this is real right we're we're doing as much as we can to make the illusion feel as your as you're in the same space so it's more than just what's on the screen it's what they do around it to pull that in so that's true of anything any type of attraction that can do both at the same time play with the virtual space play with the real space and express both at once then the illusion works right and that's where the technology can be successful I know and I've been thinking about this for quite a while I suppose in 10 or 15 years we'll have things like holographic television where you can actually be on the set with in the sets with the actors that that is sort of on the way as well well that's kind of I mean in a way that's what VR is you know been trying to do or does do and we use VR often when we're doing our design process to put our clients into a space so that they can see it and try to feel it as much as you can before it actually exists now when it comes to you know in 15 years will there be broadcasts of shows where you're in the spot the one challenge I've actually had some friends that were working on early storytelling in that virtual space the biggest challenge is when you have a director and you have a frame for media they're showing you what they want to see you know like I want you to this action takes place and that action takes place and they're crafting that story for the biggest impact when you're in a virtual space and you can look anywhere the challenge is well the biggest moment could be happening in front of you but you're looking off to the left right it's sort of like walking away from the TV at the climax well you can miss it so in some weird ways virtual reality works against the idea of storytelling but what virtually does do very well is allow you to be in more of an exploratory environment much like a video game it just depends on what type of experience you're hoping to get out of it you know if you want to wander around while something else is happening yeah I can enable you to do that but is that really the best experience you're after we'll always be exploring you know what a technology can do and how it can best express in a an experience but at the end of the day what people really want is you know they want a really great they want to be told a great story they want to be taken on a great experience they want to walk away going wow I didn't expect that and that takes crafting that takes knowing how to tell a good story how to craft a really good experience and I that's like what will groups like ours do is like how do we take the guest on a journey that they couldn't do on their own right it's more than just the technology itself it's the experience you craft for the guest so Eric near guard chief executive officer of THG creative in Pasadena California how can people find out more about what you guys do online oh you can go to THG creative.com you'll see our portfolio probably a sizzle reel about the different stuff that we do but the best way is to give us call we are happy to talk with anybody about what we do and and how we do it we hope someone will reach out and give us a ring thanks so much Eric and thanks for being part of the program on Trevor radio Australia thank you very much it's been a real pleasure